

Western Balkan hopefuls press their case

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Presented by Amazon By GERARDO FORTUNA with GREGORIO SORGI CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna back with you as Brussels prepares to welcome a revolution

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna back with you as Brussels prepares to welcome a revolutionary pairing you probably didn't have on your bingo card today: former UK Labour Leader Jeremy Corbyn and Che Guevara's daughter Aleida. More on the unexpected double act in our agenda below.

In today's Playbook:

— An obscure EU committee could decide the fate of the AfD's European home — and its money.

— MEPs are already behind on the next EU budget — and, of course, they're blaming each other for the holdup.

—Faces in the crowd: Lorenzo Biondi, Albin Kurti, Pia Lange, Wopke Hoekstra, Alexander Sell, Timčo Mucunski, Jens Flosdorff, Sergey Lavrov, Damian Boeselager, Aleksandar Vučić, Alexander Italianer and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Ian and Zoya discuss how antisemitism allegations against Jordan Bardella could ruin Marine Le Pen's presidential ambitions.

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DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — WESTERN BALKANS TELL VDL TO SORT IT OUT: Western Balkan countries hoping to join the EU will use a visit by Ursula von der Leyen to tell her they deserve to be considered much closer to joining the bloc.

“She can make that case,” Kosovo Prime Minister Albin Kurti told Playbook, calling on the European Commission president to publicly back candidate status — formal recognition of Kosovo’s path toward EU membership. “We trust that our performance has earned us a merited step forward, and that step is candidacy.”

No consolation prizes, please: While Brussels is working on ways to bring countries closer to the EU before they formally join, Kurti warned against this becoming a road to nowhere. “It must be a pathway to full EU membership, not a parallel process or a substitute.”

Here’s the problem: The Commission is readying more defined plans , including indicative timelines, for countries closest to joining. Albania, Montenegro, Ukraine and Moldova are to be given a clear route to the finish line — while others will be told to keep driving.

Welcome to the waiting room: That includes Kosovo and North Macedonia, both on von der Leyen’s itinerary alongside frontrunners Albania and Montenegro. Her challenge is to convince them Brussels isn’t creating a second tier.

Skopje wants more too: “We deserve to be in a much more advanced position than we are right now,” North Macedonia’s Foreign Minister Timčo Mucunski told POLITICO’s Sebastian Starcevic. His gripe: Skopje has heard promises before. “Within five years, you’ll become an EU member state,” he recalled being told.

Enter the sweetener: Von der Leyen is expected to point to a forthcoming review of benefits for those further back in the queue. “The president’s message will be — if you deliver on reforms, we will deliver on our side of the bargain,” a senior Commission official said, granted anonymity to speak frankly. “The more reforms they do, the more access to EU funds they get.”

Kosovo’s case: Kurti argues his country is doing its part, pointing to its alignment with EU foreign policy, including Russia sanctions. “We are not asking for shortcuts or a back door,” he said.

But there are two sides to the story: An internal Commission assessment seen by Playbook’s Gabriel Gavin estimates that Kosovo has completed only 24-26% of its Growth Plan commitments, which let aspiring members unlock EU cash and some economic benefits as they reform. Countries need to deliver before they can get the perks, another EU official said.

BIG AND BREAKING

FAMILY FIRST: The Le Pen clan is tightening its grip on France’s far right as it reckons with the fallout from the disputed allegations that National Rally President Jordan Bardella made antisemitic comments as a teenager.

WHAT’S COOKING AT THE EU-CANADA SUMMIT NEXT MONTH: A draft joint statement indicates that the two sides are looking to flesh out cooperation on critical minerals and the supply of liquefied natural gas, according to extracts seen by POLITICO’s Camille Gijs (for subscribers).

EPP’S SERBIA TEST: The European People’s Party is finalizing a report on whether to expel Serbian President Aleksandar Vučić’s SNS party — but won’t publish it until after the country’s election to “avoid interference,” according to internal notes seen by Max Grier. It yesterday expressed “disbelief” and “condemnation” over Serbia’s public commemorations of convicted war criminal Ratko Mladić.

COLD SHOULDER: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz said Moscow isn't ready for "serious talks" about ending the war in Ukraine after Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov's dismissive assessment of a meeting with his German counterpart on the weekend.

THE FIGHT OVER "MADE IN EUROPE": Brussels wants to turn "Made in Europe" from slogan into industrial strategy, but first it has to resolve these five fights — including what actually counts as European.

BUDGET BLOCKAGE

PARLIAMENT DRAGS ITS FEET: The Greens' budget negotiator has warned that turf wars and resistance to change in the European Parliament are threatening to delay a deal on the next seven-year budget. "We're so far behind that we won't even have a Parliament position by the end of next year if we continue at the same pace," Damian Boeselager told Gregorio Sorigi.

Party leaders will meet today to discuss ways to break the deadlock. Officials complain that the overlap between three different parliamentary committees — covering budget, agriculture and regional policy — has led to delays in negotiations over the National and Regional Partnership Plans (NRPPs), which include farmers' subsidies and regional payouts and cover almost half of total spending.

Parliament risks missing its pledge to agree on a position on the budget by November and start negotiations with governments early next year.

Pointing the finger: "Some agricultural MEPs in [the] negotiation team on NRPP threaten the extreme to dictate their ideas into the law. I have one simple message to those destructive forces: it's not going to work," Boeselager said.

Negotiations aren't any easier in the Council. In a fresh set of numbers expected next week, EU governments are bracing for a budget that's more than €100 billion smaller than set out in the last negotiating document in June, four EU diplomats with knowledge of the discussions told Playbook .

Who stands to lose: Countries including Italy, Spain and Poland are lobbying Ireland, which holds the six-month rotating presidency of the Council of the EU, to refrain from such cuts. "I expect there will be cuts that will make Friends of Cohesion unhappy," said one of the diplomats, referring to a group of countries pushing for a bigger budget.

Another thorny issue in Council involves funding the outermost regions including French Guiana, the Azores and the Canary Islands. France's Emmanuel Macron, Spain's Pedro Sánchez and Portugal's Luis Montenegro asked for "adequate EU funding" for those regions in a letter seen by Playbook.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The European Commission is considering big changes to its civil service exam board , the European Personnel Selection Office ... but what is EPSO? It's an EU body responsible for selecting talented candidates for jobs in the institutions and agencies. It does this by conducting tests (known as competitions) for both generalists and specialists. Some 170,000 people applied to take a generalist test earlier this year, for which fewer than 1,500 roles could be available.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked whether you've ever been briefed in a sauna. Yes, really. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

PARTY WATCH

THE LITTLE-KNOWN BODY HELPING DECIDE ESN'S FUTURE: The Committee of Independent Eminent Persons meets Thursday to start discussions on whether to deregister and defund the far-right Europe of Sovereign Nations party, the European home of Alternative for Germany.

What? The obscure committee advises the equally obscure Authority for European Political Parties, which scrutinizes financing and compliance with EU values. In July, the European Parliament approved a probe into the ESN over allegations that it breached the bloc's values, including with anti-immigration and anti-LGBT rhetoric. The committee has two months to issue an opinion.

Each EU institution has two people on the committee: The Council has German law professor Pia Lange and Lithuania's Linas Kontrimas, who ran to be an MEP in 2019. The Commission put forward ex-Commissioner Martine Reicherts and Alexander Italianer, former Commission sec-gen and deputy head of cabinet to José Manuel Barroso. The Parliament has Luca Vanoni (who has been a visiting professor at think tank MCC) and Anna Pacześniak, who sits on the scientific council of the Foundation for European Progressive Studies.

But ESN is worried about neutrality, saying "people with clear political affiliations ... have been appointed to the committee," according to Alexander Sell, a vice president. "In a true democracy, party representatives should not be involved in decisions regarding the funding of their political rivals."

Nothing to see: Spokespeople and officials from the institutions insisted all appointments are in line with the law, which forbids sitting EU officials, commissioners and MEPs from being members, as well as employees of political parties and foundations. There's no cooling-off period before joining the committee, the Parliament press service said.

Greens next: Sell said he hoped the authority would use the same process on the European Greens following allegations of antisemitism brought by a citizens' group . Antisemitism accusations are dealt with "swiftly and seriously," the European Greens said.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

AI WATCH: Leaders of some of the world's biggest AI companies have signed a voluntary accord to police their own development , Donald Trump said yesterday after hosting tech titans including Elon Musk, Mark Zuckerberg and Jensen Huang for lunch at the White House.

The U.S. president — who has previously dismissed fears about runaway AI as overblown and a "hoax" — also signed an executive order last night renaming the technology "super intelligence," my stateside colleagues report .

Meanwhile, in Europe: EU tech chief Henna Virkkunen says Brussels will keep pushing for global AI safety rules despite Washington making clear it wants no part of international regulation.

GREEK DRAMA: Greece's opposition wants to know whether Trump's ambassador to Athens, Kimberly Guilfoyle, threatened a minister during a clash over U.S. energy policy.

EAT, DRINK, REGULATE: Europe needs tougher rules on food, alcohol and tobacco to fight chronic disease, Austria's health regulator told POLITICO at the European Health Forum Gastein (more in our Morning Health Care newsletter , which is free this week from 7 a.m.).

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mostly cloudy, with a chance of a thunderstorm this evening. High 26C.

GO NORTH? NOT US: Unions are pushing back against the Commission's plans to move more executive agency staff to Brussels' troubled North District (previously reported in Playbook), accusing the Berlaymont of treating them like "second-class staff."

ON THE MOVE: Commission veteran Jens Flosdorff is leaving the Spokespersons' Service for a DG COMM directorship under boss Dana Spinant ... while Ursula von der Leyen's speechwriter Lorenzo Biondi is heading back to Rome as head of publications at think tank IAI.

LAST CALL, EUROCRATS: According to an internal note seen by Playbook, it's the last day to weigh in on the workstream recommendations feeding into the executive's massive restructuring, due by year-end.

SPOTTED ... at the inauguration of the newly redeveloped Finnish permanent representation to the EU last night: European Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen; her head of cabinet Antti Timonen; Finland's EU Ambassador Jori Arvonen; Deputy Permanent Representative Lauri Hirvonen; Sitra's Veera Heinonen; European Parliament Director for Impact Assessment and Evaluation Kajus Hagelstam; Thomas Hemmelgarn, head of the EU Policy Lab at the Commission's Joint Research Centre; MEPs Elsi Katainen and Anna-Maja Henriksson; Commission Deputy Director-General Ilkka Salmi.

SPOTTED — FOUR-LEGGED EDITION ... at Pet Power Night organized by Pet Alliance Europe at the North Rhine-Westphalia Representation, posing for pet pawtraits: Orso, belonging to the European Parliament's Elisa Fiore; Django, with FVE's Ulrike Tewes; Mathilda, with the Parliament's Julia Wagner; Lilou, with the European Disability Forum's Markaya Henderson; and consultant Dave Hemingway's dynamic duo, Opie and Jaxx.

Not spotted: Cheope, your Playbook author's cat, who wisely stayed home.

Top dog: MEP Letizia Moratti's Bianca took the overall crown in the best-buddies photo competition, while Lilou won the Brussels bubble category.

Special guests: Sanpa Dogs from Italy's San Patrignano Community, brought along by MEP Moratti. The project pairs rescued dogs undergoing rehabilitation and training with residents recovering from addiction, who gain skills and responsibility by caring for them.

NEW KID ON THE BLOCK: Something about the Brussels bubble and its highly paid, highly caffeinated officials has Belgian entrepreneurs seeing dollar signs.

This week, Mondday became the latest in a string of new specialty coffee places to open just a stone's throw from the Schuman roundabout, on Rue Froissart, branching out from its first store on the

Chaussée d'Ixelles. A hyper-cool industrial space sparsely furnished with stainless steel tables and chairs, it's unapologetically aimed at the same international market that works out at ANIMO and gets their flat whites at Bouche — right across the road.

Costly coffee: An Americano comes in at €3.50, an iced blueberry matcha at €6.50, fluffy crema di pistacchio pancakes at €14.50 and an English breakfast at €19.50. But, ironically for a spot where many of its clients won't be paying on their own dime, Mondday hasn't quite cracked printing receipts for expenses — but it will email them to you if you scribble down your address.

OFF THE RAILS: Railway enthusiasts have a rare chance to own part of Brussels' historic infrastructure, with national operator SNCB putting the former station house at Uccle-Calevoet up for sale online . The building, which the agent boasts offers great rail access to the city, could be yours for just €400,000.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Hendrik Wüst continues his Turkey trip with a pitch for investment in his home state, while Friedrich Merz will also bang the business drum in a speech to CEOs in Berlin.

Paris: Olivier Faure's camp is getting increasingly despondent about his chances of beating Raphaël Glucksmann to the Socialists' presidential nomination.

London: Andy Burnham isn't taking a step back after his big speech yesterday — he's got a full day of media appearances lined up to sell his vision to upend British politics.

Washington: All eyes were on the White House as Donald Trump hosted a private lunch with tech titans including Elon Musk, Jensen Huang, Mark Zuckerberg and Jeff Bezos.

Canberra: The Reserve Bank's decision to raise interest rates probably won't be its last this year, with the Middle East war and AI driving inflation higher.

AGENDA

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen visits Albania, where she meets President Bajram Begaj and Prime Minister Edi Rama.

— The College of European Commissioners meets in Brussels.

— Coreper II meets in Brussels at 9:30 a.m. Coreper I meets at 10 a.m.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič participates in the G20 trade ministerial in Milwaukee, Wisconsin.

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola addresses the EU Parliamentary Democracy Forum at 2 p.m. (watch live) and chairs the Parliament's Conference of Presidents meeting at 4 p.m.

— The Left group in the European Parliament holds a two-day conference on the impact of the U.S. blockade on Cuba, starting at 3 p.m. Aleida Guevara and Jeremy Corbyn are among the guest speakers today.

— Commission Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu signs the Lithuanian Social Climate Plan with Lithuania's Environment Minister Ieva Andriulaitytė.

— Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera meets Sustainable Transport Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas and Diego Aponte, president of the Mediterranean Shipping Company (MSC).

— Commission Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto meets Mario Mauro, European coordinator for the Baltic Sea–Black Sea–Aegean Sea European transport corridor.

From energy independence and tech regulation to defense capabilities and affordability, the European Pulse Seminar will explore the questions shaping Europe's policy agenda. Apply to join us in Brussels this November and contribute your views to the discussion.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Radan Kanev and Younous Omarjee; former MEPs Ivan Štefanec and Iveta Grigule-Pēterse; Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra; the Washington Post's David Herszenhorn; Finnish PSC Ambassador Juha Ottman; Eamonn Mac Aodha, head of cabinet to the EESC president.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

**A message from Amazon: Lucas Pinos' Novoma began with a simple ambition: to make well-being accessible to everyone. Founded in Toulouse, France, Novoma set out to create food supplements built on transparency, trust, and scientific rigor. As demand grew, Amazon helped Novoma reach customers across Europe. "Amazon enabled us, as a small business, to reach new markets where we hadn't existed before, and drive strong growth in just one year," says Lucas. Novoma is one of thousands of European success stories selling on Amazon. In 2024, EU-based small businesses sold more than 1.3 billion products and generated over €34 billion in sales within the EU alone. Together, these entrepreneurs support an estimated 350,000 jobs across the EU, many in local and regional communities. By providing tools, logistics, and access to customers across borders, Amazon helps small businesses, like Novoma, grow beyond their local markets while staying rooted in their communities. Learn more about how Amazon helps European businesses thrive in our latest EU Small and Medium Enterprises Impact Report at [AboutAmazon.eu](https://aboutamazon.eu). **

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